

Below is an op-ed I wrote for *The Carrboro Defender*, where I am a contributing writer.

When Young People Speak, North Carolina's Leaders Aren't Listening

By Ashley Ju Contributing Writer

After a professor was shot and killed at UNC-Chapel Hill, my fellow UNC classmates and I pleaded with our lawmakers to protect us. We were laughed out of the NC House chamber. Apparently, some lawmakers in Raleigh think the deaths of their constituents due to gun violence is funny. Two years later, the violence against young people and Americans of all ages continues, and NC lawmakers are not making it less likely that mass shootings will continue across our state and nation, but more likely.

On December 13, 2025, two Brown University students were shot and killed, while nine others were wounded during their finals week. The victims were Ella Cook, a sophomore from Alabama, and Mukhammad Aziz Umurzokov, a freshman international student from Uzbekistan.

College students simply trying to finish final exams were left with grief and lasting trauma. Once again, Americans are forced to ask: Will our leaders act at all when innocent students and tens of thousands of lives are lost to gun violence every year?

In North Carolina, the answer remains a resounding "no."

Three-fourths of North Carolinians oppose Senate Bill 50, which would eliminate concealed-carry permits and training requirements and lower the minimum age to carry a concealed

handgun from 21 to 18. The bill would make all 11 million North Carolinians less safe in their homes, grocery stores, schools, and places of worship. Yet Republican lawmakers in Raleigh don't seem to care about their constituents' safety.

Despite their failure to override Gov. Josh Stein's veto of the bill, the NC House Republicans have rescheduled the measure for debate on the legislative calendar and are set to discuss the bill on January 12, 2026.

State lawmakers supporting this legislation are choosing the gun lobby over our lives.

Evidence from other states makes the risks clear. After West Virginia passed permit-less concealed carry in 2016, firearm homicide increased by 48% and firearm suicide increased by 22% in subsequent years.

Here at home, the toll is already devastating. In 2024, 1,800 North Carolinians died from gun-related injuries, and in 2023, there were 1,767 firearm-related deaths among North Carolina residents, according to the N.C. Division of Public Health. One of those deaths was a beloved professor at UNC-Chapel Hill at the hands of one of his graduate students.

On August 28, 2023, Prof. Zijie Yan was shot and killed inside the Caudill Laboratories building on the UNC-Chapel Hill campus. The tragedy occurred during the second week of my freshman year at UNC, and I remember that day too clearly. The confusion, the blaring lockdown alerts and the fear of being killed spreading across campus faster than verified information.

Two weeks later, on September 12, student groups organized a protest and demonstration at the N.C. General Assembly. Our message was simple: We are not safe. Do your jobs. Pass laws that save lives instead of putting us in greater danger.

Rather than listening to our concerns, elected officials, including then-Speaker of the House Tim Moore, instructed police officers to escort us out of the chamber. Moore, who is now a U.S.

Congressman, mocked us, saying, “This is not a pep rally. This is the House of Representatives,” while his fellow lawmakers laughed as we were getting kicked out.

That moment is forever seared in my mind. North Carolina Republican legislators continue to push bills that make all of us less safe. They are not interested in public safety. They are interested in power.

Polling confirms how far out of touch they are with their constituents. A Meredith College survey found that more than 70% of North Carolinians strongly oppose allowing 18-year-olds to carry concealed weapons, a key provision of Senate Bill 50, yet the NC GOP continues to push the bill forward.

Tragically, the permit-less carry bill isn’t the legislature’s first offense when it comes to endangering their constituents. In 2023, lawmakers passed a law removing the requirement to obtain a permit before buying a handgun. In the 12 months that followed, there were 27 mass shootings across North Carolina, from the mountains to the coast. Today, North Carolina ranks 23rd in the nation for firearm death rates, impacting communities statewide.

SB 50 is not an isolated misstep. It is part of a broader pattern of leadership that refuses to listen to young people, ignores data, and prioritizes the gun lobby over public safety at a time when gun violence is the leading cause of death for children and teenagers in the United States.

The consequences are deeply personal. Since the shooting at UNC, I walk across campus on high alert, my body reacting in shock to every alarm or sudden noise before my mind can catch up.

This is not normal. It is not funny. It is horrifying.

It is long overdue for North Carolina's 11 million residents to stand up to corrupt politicians in Raleigh whose fealty to Donald J. Trump has become a national embarrassment. What Republican legislators fail to grasp is that the standard-bearer of their party, whom they follow on gun laws, gerrymandering, and more, Donald J. Trump, is mired in scandal after scandal and currently holds a 36% approval rating.

The NC GOP, unlike their counterparts in Indiana, has been co-opted by the Trump administration to do his dirty work — defunding public education; allowing American citizens to be harassed, brutalized, and beaten by ICE agents; and ensuring the most vulnerable among us are left out in the cold with the cutting of SNAP benefits. This is a critical moment in the history of our democracy, so it's the responsibility of all North Carolinians to get involved in their communities and push back against the authoritarian tactics of the NC GOP, because our voices matter.

SB 50 threatens public safety and puts our friends, families, and communities at risk. We cannot allow it to become law. It is incumbent upon all North Carolinians to contact their state representatives and demand that they oppose the override of Gov. Stein's veto of SB 50. We all have a duty to educate ourselves and one another on bills that threaten our safety and security.

When young people speak, our leaders must listen. Our lives depend on it.